

BREAKING SHACKLES

The process of normalisation of women is leaving men shell-shocked

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The collective subconscious of women has been inundated with insults from eve teasers, feudal families, rapists...



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The hand that rocks the cradle rules the world but the same hands are also stained with blood. A spate of cold, calculated murders masterminded by women, in the last few years, has challenged the basic norms of understanding "feminine" behaviour. But who said women had monopoly over "nurturance" alone. While interviewing women involved in the 1993 riots, three sentences uttered by them still ring in my ears: "*Hamare hathon me bhi taqat hai*", "*Hum abhi chup nahin rah sakte*", and "*Hum kuch galat nahin kar rahen hain*". Metaphorically, these expressions are a product of complex historical processes where chronic trauma has been a reality. The collective subconscious has been inundated with insults from eve-teasers, chauvinistic feudal families, rapists and many more. The visual of an honour killing in a village repulsively reverberates across the "psyche" of the country, more so of women.

Though a large number of women live apparently unscathed lives, yet the seething anger is passed on to their daughters. "I feel like stabbing my relative who was all over me when I was a kid" and "I have made my daughter strong so that she will not take shit like me" are sentences uttered by at least one-fifth of the women. News about women killing their lovers/husband fill crime pages today. All of them believe that the "anonymity" of cities hit by reckless globalisation will be an armour. None feels the need to talk to a sympathetic adult about their turmoil. Disconnection between human beings is a bigger virus than HIV and the large gatherings at religious discourses are just a superficial balm. The Indian woman is also asking for more. Equity, excitement and empowerment are global utterances which are now being echoed in *Mera Bharat Mahan*. The middle class *bahu* wants freedom in the kitchen, bedroom and the bank, failing which she is prepared to walk out.

Cutting the murdered body into many pieces by the Mumbai couple is an extreme example of dehumanisation. The country is passing through a chronic disaster syndrome with terrorism, Naxal violence, and micro-macro disasters hitting us repeatedly. The angst of globalisation leads to a peculiar anger leading to violence, suicide, depression, addiction, sexual offences and dehumanisation. I have come across stories of young girls killing their severely-abusive alcoholic fathers and escaping punishment as the society justified it. These acts are a process of normalisation of women that is leaving men shell-shocked. "We were conned in being made to believe like sacrificial martyr goddesses which we are not...we are as vulnerable as men...let us be simply normal", is an echo one hears repeatedly.

and becoming more liberal. Thirty years ago nobody had the guts to move out of a bad marriage but women these days are not willing to compromise and our serials are reflecting this."

In the days of mobile phones and satellite television, the modes of communication are providing newer and more furtive engagement platforms to men and women. Outside of the bedroom, the new-age mating game is played out on the short messaging service (SMS). According to operators, more than half of these messages are generated between 7 a.m. and 9 a.m. and between 11 p.m. and 2 a.m..

Bharti sees another disturbing trend in the nonchalance with which people commit crimes, believing that they can get away with it. After the murder, Jerome returned to Kochi while Susairaj went to the police station with Grover's friends to register a missing complaint. It was only after interrogation that she broke down and confessed.

While most try to hide their actions behind the anonymity a buzzing metro offers them, others merely give vent to their pent-up frustrations without caring for the consequences. With the breakdown of the joint family, which provided a strong support system, people have few they can call their own or talk to. And when there is a sign of any of these people letting them down, morally, physically or sexually, it evokes uncontrolled passion. Unlike the West, counselling facilities in India are almost non-existent. A few decades ago an overarching desire to succeed wasn't there nor was there such intense competition. Neither were people so ambitious and that has changed the social fabric. While the police cannot prevent these crimes, society can play key role in the prevention of such crimes. In nuclear families, where both parents are working, social values are not instilled well enough in children. Be it at a community level or within corporations, the need of the hour is a robust counselling system equipped to pick up distress signals in people and help them out of their entrapments. In the absence of such preventives, love triangles like that of Susairaj, Grover and Jerome will continue to result in cold-blooded brutality.

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